



Breaking through: Jharkhand won the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy on its first appearance in the final, becoming the tournament's 12th champion. SHAYAN ACHARYA

A DHONI BLUEPRINT, AN ISHAN FINISH

Jharkhand's first SMAT title came from structural clarity, M.S. Dhoni's counsel, and a captain who **backed his players** without flinching.

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They were all waiting with bated breath. By then, it was clear that Jharkhand was about to create history by winning its maiden Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy, needing just one more wicket.

While the families of the cricketers

and officials watching the final from the president's pavilion at the Maharashtra Cricket Association Stadium in Gahunje, on the outskirts of Pune, seemed overjoyed, two gentlemen sitting on the other side waited before letting the emotions take over.

As one of his friends urged him to celebrate, Jharkhand State Cricket Association (JSCA) secretary Saurabh Tiwary muttered, "Arey, ruk jaao thoda (wait a bit)". Sitting beside him, JSCA joint secretary Shahbaz Nadeem nodded in agreement before adding with a cheeky smile, "Cricket hai bhai,